

of support for a lot of codecs, the horrible menu system, the utterly clunky navigation – WMP has more going against it than for it.

So of course, an alternative was required. It wasn't long before programmer Gabor Kovacs came out with the free and open-source The Core Pocket Media Player (TCPMP).



The player can play almost every video codec under the sun

The player is so feature-rich and well polished, it's difficult to know where to start. If we really had to pick, the best part would be the wide gamut of formats it supports: AVI (both DivX and Xvid), MKV, MP4, M4A, OGG, OGM, ASF and WMV (on Windows Mobile devices).

The lack of FLV might disturb some, especially given the format's popularity these days with YouTube and other online video-sharing sites. Worry not, though. There's a simple plug-in that offers a workaround, available at www.mobytube.net. There's also a WMV plug-in, which some Palm users have had success with.

The videos can be played off the phone's built-in memory or any memory card you fit in. A simple menu control scheme goes a long way in enhancing the usability. It's not meant to be used without a stylus, but we found it pretty easy anyway.

Tap the 'Play' button with your thumb to start your video, and tap it again to stop it. The 'Full' button will take you to full-screen mode while tapping the screen again will pause the video. And of course, the slider bar for the video's footage completes the navigation package.

The videos play flawlessly, offering rich colours and good sound quality. A small 'Preferences' button offers volume control, playback speed, display settings and other options.

TCPMP also offers the option of creating a playlist, although it's not as robust as that of most other media players. For once, even Windows Media Player scores better in a department! Still, it's handy enough to queue up your media, be it videos, songs